THE SCARY NUMBER THAT HAD ALREADY STOPPED MATTERING

I carried it around for five weeks like a debt. Then I looked, and it had already been paid.

TIME SPENT CARRYING IT

5

weeks of low grade dread,
against the ninety seconds it
took to check once I finally did.

Nobody was hiding it from me. I had simply decided in advance what the answer was going to be.

HOW A STALE NUMBER SURVIVES

01	You hear it once, in a hurry, from a system you trust	DAY ONE
02	You build a plan around it instead of checking it	WEEK ONE
03	Checking now means admitting you planned on a guess	WEEK TWO
04	The dread becomes the reason not to look	WEEK THREE
05	The number changes and nothing tells you	WEEK FOUR

Step three is where it actually gets expensive.

THE TWO PRICES

THE NUMBER

Already paid

Handled, resolved, closed. It had stopped being true weeks before I got around to being afraid of it.

THE CARRYING

Five weeks

Decisions deferred, a plan built sideways around a thing that was not there, and attention spent on nothing.

The carrying cost exceeded the number. That is the part worth saying out loud.

> **Go and look. A number you are afraid of is a number you have stopped measuring, and it is probably no longer the number.**

THE SAME INSTINCT THAT MADE ME COUNT FILL RATES INSTEAD OF TRUSTING A REPORT.

Every claim in my posts carries a date for exactly this reason.

WHAT I CHANGED

Anything I am avoiding gets a date and a source written next to it. If I cannot say where a number came from and when, it is not a number, it is a mood.

And the check goes in the calendar the same afternoon, because the whole failure mode is the deferral rather than the arithmetic.

THE THREE IN EVERY SHOP

/ The receivable you are sure is still outstanding GO LOOK

/ The client you assume has left GO LOOK

/ The subscription you think you need GO LOOK

One afternoon, three checks, and at least one of them will be out of date.

THE SYSTEM THAT MAKES ME LOOK

Every stale deal gets four questions every fourteen days, and every answer writes a record. Promo shops can request access.

HYGIENE SWEEP | DATED RECEIPTS | ACCESS BY REQUEST

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